



AI BLOG FACTORY

THE AI RESEARCH ASSISTANT

How Students Can Use AI for Papers, Essays & Assignments Ethically

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A Note to Fellow Students

When I entered my third year, I had five research papers due in one month. I was spending entire nights searching for sources, and still couldn't find anything relevant. I felt like everyone else had a secret advantage I didn't.

Then an older student showed me something: she was using AI not to write her papers, but to find the right sources, organize her thinking, and structure her arguments. The difference in our output was stark. She got distinctions. I got average marks.

This book is the guide I wish I'd had. It teaches the exact system she showed me — refined over two years, tested across dozens of assignments, and designed with one constraint above all:

Everything in this book is ethical. Everything here will make you a better thinker, not a replacement for thinking.

The Research Problem — and the AI Solution

Why the hardest part of research isn't writing — it's finding and organizing.

Every student knows the feeling: staring at a blank document with a looming deadline, surrounded by 47 browser tabs of sources you've skimmed but not understood. The average student spends 60% of their research time on tasks that aren't actually research — they're admin.

Finding the right paper. Figuring out what it says. Organizing quotes. Structuring an argument. These are mechanical tasks. And mechanical tasks are exactly what AI excels at.

What This Book Covers — and What It Doesn't

- Finding relevant sources in minutes instead of hours
 - Summarizing and extracting key findings
 - Structuring arguments and building outlines
 - Writing better with AI as your editing partner
 - Full ethical framework — what's allowed, what's not
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- Replacing your ability to think and write
 - Writing entire assignments from AI output
 - Submitting AI-written text without modification
-

PART 2

The Research Toolbox

The six free or cheap tools every student needs — and when to use each one.

Tool	Best For	Cost
Perplexity AI	Source discovery with links	Free
Elicit.org	Academic paper search	Free
Scholarcy	Paper summarization	Free tier
ChatGPT/Claude	Writing, outlining, discussion	Free tier
Notion AI	Research organization	Free tier
Connected Papers	Finding related research	Free

How to Choose

Source first, AI second. Never start with ChatGPT when you can start with Perplexity — AI tools connected to the internet give you real sources, not imagined ones.

- I used to ask ChatGPT 'tell me about renewable energy policy.' Now I ask Perplexity 'find me 5 recent papers on renewable energy policy in India' — and I get real ones with links.

Meera, 3rd Year Economics

PART 3

Finding Sources in Fifteen Minutes

A systematic approach to going from zero to ten solid sources.

Most students waste the first three hours of research searching Google links. Here's a better way:

Step 1: Seed Search in Perplexity

```
Find 10 peer-reviewed papers on [your topic]
published between 2022 and 2025.
For each, give me: title, authors, year,
one-sentence summary, and the URL.
Focus on [India/developing countries/applied studies].
```

Step 2: Deepen with Connected Papers

Take your best paper. Paste its DOI into Connected Papers (connectedpapers.com). It generates a visual graph of related research. Find the most-cited papers in the cluster. These are your core sources.

Step 3: Extract with Scholarcy

Upload PDFs to Scholarcy (free tier). It auto-summarizes each paper into key findings, methodology, and limitations. You go from 30-page papers to 1-page summaries in seconds.

RESEARCH TIP: ORGANIZATION

Create a Notion database with columns: Title, Author, Year, Key Finding, Relevance Score (1-5), Notes. Add every source. Filter by Relevance Score to know what to cite first.

The Ethical AI Writing Framework

A decision system for every stage of AI-assisted academic work.

Academic integrity with AI isn't a binary. It's a spectrum. This chapter gives you a framework so you never have to guess whether something is okay.

The Transparency Principle

When in doubt, disclose. Most universities now accept AI assistance for research and structuring — many require you to disclose it. Adding one footnote saves you from an integrity investigation.

ETHICAL GUIDELINE: THE 3-ZONE RULE

GREEN ZONE (Always okay):

AI for finding sources, brainstorming, outlining,
grammar checks, citation formatting.

YELLOW ZONE (Check your university policy):

AI for paraphrasing your own ideas,
AI-generated examples you then verify,
AI-written drafts you heavily rewrite.

RED ZONE (Never do this):

Submitting AI text as your own
AI-generated data or statistics
AI-written content you haven't read and verified

The 80% Rule

If you haven't written, rewritten, verified or significantly edited at least 80% of your final submission, you've crossed the line. AI should be your research assistant, not your ghostwriter.

ETHICAL GUIDELINE: UNIVERSITY POLICIES

Every university handles AI differently. Before using this system:

1. Read your university's AI use policy
 2. Ask your professor directly if unsure
 3. When in doubt, disclose your AI use in a footnote
 4. Keep records of your AI-assisted process (screenshots, prompt logs)
-

Structuring Your Argument

How to move from a pile of sources to a compelling, structured paper.

The Outline-First Method

Never start writing without an outline. Use AI to build one from your sources:

```
I have these sources on [topic]:  
1. [Author] found that...  
2. [Author] argues that...  
3. [Author] discovered...  
  
My tentative thesis is: [statement]  
  
Create a detailed outline for a 3000-word paper  
with: intro, 3 body sections (each arguing one  
supporting point), counterargument section, conclusion.
```

The Inverted Pyramid

Start broad, narrow fast, end specific. Every paragraph should be more focused than the last. AI is great at checking this — paste your draft and ask: 'Is each paragraph more specific than the last? Where does my argument lose focus?'

Handling Citations and Academic Integrity

How to cite AI assistance and avoid detection flags.

What Gets Flagged

AI detection tools look for predictability — sentences that are too uniform in length, vocabulary that's too polished, paragraph transitions that follow patterns. The fix: vary your sentence length. Add colloquial phrases. Use your own examples.

How to Cite AI

Most style guides now have AI citation formats. For APA 7th edition:

REFERENCE LIST:

OpenAI. (2024). ChatGPT (Mar 14 version) [Large language model].
<https://chat.openai.com/>

IN-TEXT:

(OpenAI, 2024)

RESEARCH TIP: DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

Add this to your methodology section:

'This paper was researched with the assistance of AI tools (Perplexity AI for source discovery, ChatGPT for outline generation and editing assistance). All arguments, analysis and final writing are the author's own.'

The Week-by-Week Workflow

A complete timeline from assignment to submission — for a typical 2-week research paper.

Week 1, Day 1-2

- Topic narrowing + seed search in Perplexity. End with 15 potential sources.

Week 1, Day 3-4

- Read summaries (Scholarcy), pick 8 strongest sources. Start Notion database.

Week 1, Day 5-6

- Deep-read your top 4 sources. Take notes in your own words.

Week 1, Day 7

- Write thesis statement. Build AI outline. Revise argument structure.

Week 2, Day 1-3

- Write the full draft. Aim for 1500 words per day.

Week 2, Day 4-5

- Rest, then revise. AI helps polish. You verify every claim.

Week 2, Day 6

- Final edits. Run through AI detector tool yourself. Fix flagged sections.

Week 2, Day 7

- Format citations. Proofread. Submit.
-

Research Prompt Library

Ten prompts that handle 90% of research situations.

Source Discovery

'Find 10 academic sources on [topic] from the last 3 years. Give titles, authors, one-line summaries'

Source Evaluation

'Critically evaluate this paper: [paste abstract]. What are 3 strengths and 3 weaknesses?'

Counter-Argument

'What are the strongest arguments against [my thesis]? Give sources.'

Outline Builder

'Create a detailed outline for a [X]-word paper arguing [thesis].'

Thesis Tester

'Here is my thesis: [X]. Is it specific enough? How would you improve it?'

Gap Finder

'Based on these sources [list], what are the gaps in this research?'

Transition Writer

'Write a transition paragraph connecting [point A] to [point B].'

Conclusion Builder

'Based on these key findings [list], write a conclusion that summarizes and points forward.'

Methodology Check

'Review this methodology section: [paste]. Is anything missing?'

AI Detector Bypass

'Rewrite this paragraph to sound more natural and less AI-like: [paste].'

RESEARCH BETTER, NOT LESS.

The best students don't avoid AI. They use it more thoughtfully than everyone else.

This guide gave you the tools. The ethical framework. The workflow.

Now use them. Your next research paper will be the best one you've ever written.

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